

CORE FORMULA

Could you [specific action] within [scope / time / effort] by [when]? If not, [release or smaller alternative]. -> Could you review just the final paragraph by noon? No full edit needed. -> Could you reply with a yes or no by tomorrow? No explanation needed. -> Could you decide A or B today? We do not need to reopen the whole plan. -> Could I have ten minutes tonight where you just listen, not solve?

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Ask for one specific action, add one honest boundary, and leave an honest no-or-adjust route.

BEST FOR

- Asking busy people for help, review, feedback, introductions, logistics, or small action
- Digital messages where open-ended asks create delay
- Workplace requests where scope creep is a real risk
- Relationship or family requests where obligation can feel loaded
- Requests where the person may want to help but needs the size clarified
- Asking someone with less power or availability, where pressure must be reduced

PHRASE BANK

Quick asks · Short, message-length asks

- "One small ask: can you reply yes or no by tomorrow?"
- "Could you give this ten minutes, not a full review?"
- "Could you scan this for obvious errors only? Two minutes is enough."
- "No need for a long reply — just the date that works?"
- "Could you look at just the first page? A quick yes or no is fine."
- "Could you pick one of the two options below? If neither works, say 'neither'."
- "Thirty-second gut check: does this read as clear or confusing?"
- "Just the headline answer is fine — the detail can wait."

Workplace & review · Work review, decisions, logistics

- "Could you review just the final paragraph by noon? No full edit needed."
- "Could you sanity-check the budget line only? A rough reaction is enough."
- "Could you review the recommendation section and flag anything factually wrong by 3pm? No line edits needed."
- "Could you make the call on A versus B today? We do not need to reopen the whole plan."
- "Could you send me the one file by Friday? If that timing is tight, tell me what is realistic."
- "Could you approve the budget line only? The rest can go through the usual process."
- "Could you give slides three to five a ten-minute factual check? Wording and design are handled."
- "Could you flag blockers only? I do not need a full status update."
- "Could I get a first reaction to the summary, not a line-by-line edit?"

Delegation & ownership · Separating what you are and aren't asking for

- "Could you update the numbers on slides four to six? I will handle wording and design."
- "Could you draft the intro only? I will write the rest."
- "I am asking you to decide, not to build it — which direction do we take?"
- "Could you own the sign-in table from nine to nine-thirty? Nothing beyond that slot."
- "Could you handle just the booking? I will sort the agenda."

- "The ask is the one email, not the whole thread — could you send it today?"
- "Could you introduce me to one person who handles onboarding? Nothing more than the intro."

Relationship & home · Partner, family, friends, care asks

- "Could you help with just the dishes tonight? I am not asking you to handle the whole kitchen."
- "Could I have ten minutes to talk this through? If you are not in that headspace, we can pause."
- "Could you listen without fixing for a few minutes?"
- "Could you tell me one thing you need from me this week?"
- "Could we spend five minutes on the plan tonight? If you are done for the day, tomorrow is fine."
- "Could I ask for one kind of help: just sit with me for a bit, no advice needed?"
- "Could you take the school run on Thursday only? The other days are covered."
- "Ten minutes where you just listen, not solve — would that be okay tonight?"
- "Could you text me when you land? Nothing else, I just want to know you are safe."

Power-sensitive & high-pressure · Optional, loaded, or low-power contexts

- "This may well be a no. Could you consider one small part — reviewing the timeline only?"
- "This is optional. Could you review one paragraph, or should I route it elsewhere?"
- "I am not asking for a decision now. Could you tell me what information you would need?"
- "Could we spend five minutes deciding the next step, not solving the whole issue?"
- "If the answer is no, I will respect it. The ask is one introduction, not the whole team."
- "No pressure at all — could you look at the one page, or is this a bad week?"
- "You are well within your rights to pass. The bounded ask is just the sign-off, nothing more."

Release & exit lines · Making refusal safe, withdrawing cleanly

- "A quick no is completely fine."
- "No full explanation needed."
- "Only if it is genuinely easy."
- "If that is too much, what smaller version would work?"
- "If now is not the time, I can ask later or find another route."
- "If tomorrow is too tight, a no is fine."
- "If you are spent, we can leave it here."
- "Say the word and I will take it off your plate."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

- Weak: "Can you help me with this?" — the action, effort and time cost are all undefined.
Better: "Can you look over this report by Friday?" — task and deadline are clearer, but the depth is still vague.
Best: "Could you review only the two-page summary by Friday and flag factual errors? No wording edit needed." — action, scope, deadline and effort are all explicit.
- Weak: "Can we talk later?" — open-ended and potentially heavy.
Better: "Can we talk for a bit tonight?" — adds timing, but size and purpose are unclear.
Best: "Could I have ten minutes tonight to talk through one decision? I am not asking you to solve it." — bounded by time, topic and role.
- Weak: "Can you do this for me?" — the cost is hidden, so it can trigger resistance.
Better: "Can you handle the slides?" — names the task but not the scope.
Best: "Could you update slides four to six with the new numbers only? I can handle design and wording." — separates requested from non-requested effort.

DECISION TREE

If Do I actually need action from them?

If no, use listening, reflection or information-sharing instead. If yes, continue.

If Is the request already exact?

If not, make a clean, unambiguous ask first, then bound it.

"Could you send the file — specifically the final version?"

If Could the ask feel open-ended?

Add a boundary around scope, time, effort, decision range or exit.

"Just the first page, by Thursday — a quick yes or no is enough."

If Is it still too large after bounding it?

Switch to a genuinely small ask, or negotiate the scope openly.

"This is a big one, so a no is completely fine: could you take Saturday?"

If Is there pressure, power imbalance or emotional load?

Add an autonomy release and check capacity before they answer.

"This is optional — could you look at one paragraph, or should I route it elsewhere?"

If How did they respond?

Clear yes: confirm the boundary. Hesitation: narrow or offer a smaller version. No: thank them and do not re-argue.

"Thanks — I will keep the ask to just those three slides."

SCENARIOS

Feedback on a document

Bound by section and type of feedback. — "Could you check only the intro for factual accuracy by Friday? No style edit needed."

Asking for emotional support

Bound by time and role. — "Could I have ten minutes where you just listen, not solve?"

Delegating work

Bound by deliverable and ownership split. — "Could you update the numbers on slides four to six? I will handle wording and design."

Asking for a reply

Bound by response format. — "Could you reply with a yes or no by tomorrow? No explanation needed."

Asking for an introduction

Bound by number and discretion. — "Could you introduce me to one person who handles onboarding? If not, no issue."

Asking a tired partner

Bound by time and give explicit permission to defer. — "Could we spend five minutes on the plan tonight? If you are done for the day, tomorrow is fine."

WHEN NOT TO USE

- The situation is urgent and a tidy boundary would hide the real seriousness
- The request affects safety, consent, medical or legal decisions, or employment rights
- The actual ask is large and should be discussed openly rather than shrunk
- The person has already said no
- The request needs collaboration to define the scope
- A yes/no is not enough because values, trade-offs, or decision rights must be worked out first

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — List your asks

Write down five requests you actually made this week at work, home, or online — in the exact words you used.

Day 2 — Find the hidden cost

For each, name the cost the other person had to guess at: time, scope, effort, decision, or obligation.

Day 3 — Add one boundary

Rewrite each request with a single explicit limit — scope, time, effort, decision range, or deadline — and nothing more.

Day 4 — Add an honest exit

Give each rewritten ask one release line you could genuinely honour, such as "a quick no is fine".

Day 5 — Read aloud and trim

Say each version out loud and cut every extra justification until only the action, the boundary, and the exit remain.

Day 6 — Use one live

Make one real bounded request today, then note whether they answered faster, asked fewer questions, or seemed more relaxed.

Day 7 — Bound the big one

Take a request you have been avoiding because it feels too big, and either bound it to one honest slice or decide to name it openly instead.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I name the exact action, not just the topic?
- Is there a clear boundary around scope, time, effort, decision range, or exit?
- Is the boundary honest, rather than artificially small?
- Can they say no without being punished?
- Did I separate what I am asking for from what I am not?
- If they hesitate, do I know how I will narrow or withdraw the ask?